BLIND INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY

13062 Spruce Place

Thornton, CO 80602

Executive Summary for Reddit

Introduction

This is the executive summary written for the audit done on the Reddit website. This audit was done to the standards of the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines 2.2, which is the Worldwide Web Consortium's written and selected listed criteria for a given website, or web application to be considered accessible. Following any or some of these guidelines will lead to a web product being more accessible which in turn lends to the usability of the item. Accessibility remediations of defects and flagged problems will help all types of people from all walks of life including but not limited to blind and low vision groups, deaf and hard of hearing, groups where mobility disabilities are a concern, speech disabilities, photosensitivity, and combinations of these, and some accommodation for learning disabilities and cognitive limitations. These guidelines address accessibility through the use of laptops, desktops, tablets and mobile devices.

Note: There was no mobile testing done for this specific accessibility audit.

Explanations and Defects

A defect is flagged when it is:

- blocking a user from either completing or committing to an action.
- not legible.
- if it is missing certain accessible web attributes that assist in specific groups of people accessing the content in question.
- anything that may hinder a user or user groups from accessing the web content.

When a problem is marked as:

- **One** (1), one can think of the problem as cosmetic. These kinds of problems are of the lowest priority and whether or not they get changed is of very little consequence.
- **Two** (2), Low to medium, usually indicates that the issue should be remedied, but there's no extreme pressure to do so.
- **Three** (3), can be medium or medium to high, depending on the nature of the problem. For example, if a page had headings with uninformative labels, it could easily be written up as a three, but the presence of meaningful text and an accurate heading hierarchy in the web document ensures the score received is better than it would have been should the headings have been present with no labels whatsoever. It could be called a medium as opposed to medium to high. This is not isolated to issues flagged as a three. A problem normally flagged as a one might get pushed up to being called low to medium if the problem is such that it: causes problems for more than one group of users, causes issues over multiple pieces of assistive technology, or maybe, in context to a situation, it's particularly important to complete a certain task on a given site.
- **Four** (4), is high and may be considered as high to being a blocker depending on the specific issue in context.
- **Five** (5) is the most severe. Fives prevent a task or an action from being completed and/or committed respectively. A defect rated a "5" is considered to be a blocker. That is to say that it prevents a group or groups from accessing some specific piece of content, or completing some specific action in a process on a website or web application.

Defects

Upon conducting this audit, a total of 19 screen reader-related errors were discovered. Although there were no blockers or cosmetic errors, these low to high-severity errors impacted the overall accessibility of the website.

Breakdown

This summary will be mapped onto the severity ratings of the defects/violations flagged during the audit. In order to advise on the necessity of remediation measures and the order in which different reparations should be applied, defects will be covered in a blocker-to-cosmetic (top-down), ranking order. The screen reader concerns will be explained.

Screen Reader Guidelines and Violations

While evaluating the Reddit websites from a screen reader standpoint, there were several instances where the WCAG success criteria were not being met. Most of the issues impact

visually impaired users who navigate and interact using only a screen reader and keyboard. The following breakdowns and explanations walk through the success criteria that are not currently being met and provide insight into what the goal /intent is for each one.

In total, there were 19 instances where the success criteria were not being met.

Note: NVDA was used to perform this audit on Reddit using Google Chrome on Windows 11.

Blocking Severity Errors

Note: There were no errors documented at a severity level of blocking.

High Severity Errors

1.2.5 Audio Description - 1 Instance

Provide an audio description for pre-recorded videos. The intent of this success criterion is to provide people who are blind or visually impaired with an audio description that explains visual information in the video that isn't communicated through the audio. If not remediated, users won't know what the video is about.

1.1.1 Non-text Content - 1 Instance

A text alternative description should be provided for all images and non-text content. This success criterion helps people who have difficulty perceiving visual content. This impacts screen reader users as assistive technology can read text aloud, present it visually, or convert it to braille. If not remediated, the users won't know what the content is about.

1.3.1 Info and Relationships - 1 Instance

Information about content structure is available to the screen reader user. For instance, headings should be identified as headings. This success criterion impacts screen readers by adapting content according to the needs of individual users. They are able to navigate the page using "H" to look at different headings. They are also able to navigate different headings, links, etc through an element list. If this is not remediated, users won't be able to understand the semantics of the page and cause confusion.

1.3.2 Meaningful Sequence - 1 Instance

The content must be read in a meaningful order by assistive technologies. This Success Criterion affects assistive technology users. If not remediated, it may confuse or disorient users when assistive technology reads the content in the wrong order.

*Note: There was 1 additional instance documented at a severity level lower than a 4, high severity.

2.4.2 Page Titled - 1 Instance

The webpage must have a meaningful title that is descriptive. In other words, the page title should describe the topic or purpose of the page and help users identify which page they're viewing. Essentially, page titles help users identify and distinguish different pages. This criterion impacts multiple kinds of disabilities. For example, people with cognitive disabilities, limited short-term memory or reading disabilities can benefit by quickly identifying the content by its title. People who are visually impaired can benefit by being able to differentiate content when multiple web pages are open. If not remediated, it may cause confusion as to what page the user is currently on.

2.4.4 Link Purpose (In Context) - 1 Instance

The purpose of each link should be clear from the link text or context. In simple terms, if you hear the link by itself or the link with its surrounding context, then you should be able to understand what it does and where it leads you. This impacts both screen reader users and people with cognitive disabilities. If not remediated, they might have difficulty navigating the page and might click links that they don’t need to visit.

2.1.1 Keyboard - 1 Instance

Everything you can do with a mouse should also be possible with a keyboard. This criterion impacts multiple kinds of disabilities. For example, people with hand tremors find using a mouse difficult and prefer a keyboard. People who are visually impaired and use screen readers rely on keyboards to navigate websites. If this is not remediated, it will limit where you can click or navigate to using a keyboard.

*Note: There was 1 additional instance documented at a severity level lower than a 4, high severity.

2.4.3 Focus Order - 1 Instance

Keyboard focus must move in a logical order. In other words, when using the “Tab” key, the order that you use the tab key must be similar to how you visually see and logically read the page. This criterion impacts multiple kinds of disabilities. For instance, people with mobility

impairments who must rely on keyboard access benefit from a logical focus order. People with reading difficulties might lose their reading order if the focus order jumps somewhere else. If not remediated, users might become disoriented or confused when tabbing takes them someplace unexpected.

3.2.2 On Input - 1 Instance

Changing a setting on a user interface component should not automatically cause a major change in context unless users have been advised of that behavior beforehand. This criterion impacts multiple kinds of disabilities. Users with reading or intellectual disabilities might benefit if a warning is provided to state that there will be a change of context due to the certain action. Screen readers would benefit from an announcement warning them about the context change due to the input. If not remediated, users might become disoriented or confused when selecting something or typing something in input fields takes them someplace unexpected.

3.3.2 Labels or Instructions - 1 Instance

Text labels or clear instructions must be provided when data input is required. This criterion impacts all users. Overall, providing labels and instructions can prevent users from making incomplete or incorrect form submissions. If not remediated, users might enter information incorrectly and be forced to navigate the page again to fix submission errors.

3.3.3 Error Suggestion - 1 Instance

Error suggestions must be provided when input errors are known. This criterion impacts all users. For example, people who are visually impaired must be able to hear what they can do to fix their errors. People with cognitive disabilities would benefit from a clear explanation on how to fix the error. If this is not remediated, users won't know how to correct the errors and won't be able to proceed.

*Note: There were 2 additional instances documented at severity levels lower than a 4, high severity.

4.1.2 Name, Role, Value - 3 Instances

Every interactive element must have a name, role, and value. In other words, they must tell a screen reader what it is, its name, and its current state. A name is what the element is called, such as "submit". A role describes what kind of element it is, such as a "button". A value can be

a current value entered into an input field, such as a text or number (aka integer). This success criterion impacts assistive technology users as it gathers information about the element, the current activation mode, and keeps up to date on the status of interactive elements in the content. For example, it is crucial for a visually impaired user to hear that the dropdown menu they selected has expanded, which is a state. If not remediated, then screen readers are unable to convey the statuses of the interactive elements and might have difficulty maneuvering the page.

4.1.3 Status Messages - 1 Instance

When a status message or important advisory text appears, it must be announced to assistive technologies without requiring the user to lose their focus. This success criterion impacts screen reader users as it announces important changes in the content. If not remediated, screen readers may miss important updates if those messages aren't announced, such as when you filter for results and it changes the amount of results.

Medium Severity Errors

All of the medium severity errors were documented at a higher severity level and have already been outlined.

Low Severity Errors

All of the low severity errors were documented at a higher severity level and have already been outlined.

Cosmetic Severity Errors

Note: There were no errors documented at a severity level of cosmetic.

Important Note

It is important to note that some instances may reflect a grouping of the same issue appearing multiple times on the same task or across multiple tasks. This is done to reduce repetitive content and help guide remediation plans and strategies. It is also important to note that some instances may be marked with a lower severity depending on the specific case. These instances are noted below each success criteria to ensure those items are not overlooked.

Conclusion

In conclusion, across the 19 screen reader errors documented, none of them were marked as blocking users from accessing or engaging with Reddit's webpages or cosmetic errors. 15 instances were marked as a high severity issue that would impact a large number of users with disabilities who rely on and use assistive technology. The remaining 4 documented issues were marked as medium or low severity items, which impact those who rely on and use assistive technology, but not in a necessarily major way. It is advised to start remediation with the high severity errors before moving on to the medium severity items before moving to the low severity items or cosmetic items.

Thank you for this opportunity.